

Understanding and Managing Emotional Reactions in Customers Through the CUE Model in Project Management

In the Components of User Experience (CUE) model by Van der Linden et al. (2019), *emotional reactions* are highlighted as a key outcome of human-technology interaction, influenced by perceived instrumental and non-instrumental qualities. Emotional responses significantly shape overall judgments, usage behaviour, and choice between alternatives, making them crucial to manage in customer-focused project delivery (Van der Linden et al., 2019). As a Project Manager, actively addressing and shaping customer emotional reactions ensures that solutions not only meet functional requirements but also resonate with customers' affective expectations.

Research indicates that emotional arousal during customer experiences is dynamic and strongly predicts subsequent behaviour and satisfaction. Caruelle et al. (2024) demonstrate that both peak emotional intensity and its variation over time influence approach behaviours and engagement. Consequently, project managers should map the emotional journey of customers throughout the project lifecycle, identifying “moments of truth” where reinforcement of positive emotions or mitigation of negative emotions is required.

Emotional intelligence (EI) in project leadership is a critical factor in managing stakeholders' emotional reactions. Chaudhry et al. (2025) found that project managers with higher EI exhibit improved communication, conflict resolution, and stakeholder satisfaction. Similarly, Khan et al. (2023) observed that emotionally intelligent leaders enhance team collaboration and trust, which reduces friction in project delivery. Developing EI through training in self-awareness, empathy, and adaptive responses equips managers to navigate emotional peaks and troughs during interactions with clients.

In addition, empathy-driven UX design practices allow proactive management of emotional reactions rather than purely reactive measures. Rahaman et al. (2023) highlight that AI-driven

frameworks can anticipate users' emotional needs using behavioural and contextual data, enabling personalised system responses that foster positive emotional experiences. Project managers can integrate this by conducting early user testing focused on affective needs, creating feedback loops to monitor emotional responses, and adapting solutions to maximise user satisfaction.

In conclusion, managing emotional reactions as a Project Manager requires combining emotional intelligence, emotional journey mapping, and empathy-centered design practices. These strategies not only address immediate emotional responses but also embed affective considerations into the user experience lifecycle, enhancing overall satisfaction, engagement, and loyalty (Caruelle et al., 2024; Chaudhry et al., 2025; Rahaman et al., 2023).

References

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